



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: City School

School Website: <https://cityschooltexas.org/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

City School TX 78744 (Austin, TX) presents a fundamentally formation-focused, faith-inspired private Christian education modeled on Charlotte Mason principles. The school publicly articulates a Christ-centered, holistic approach to forming minds, hearts, and communities, with explicit emphasis on character development, habits, living books, and a pedagogy centered on narration, communal discussion, and reverence for the divine order. Evidence from the school's public materials shows core commitments to truth and God, a beautiful and orderly environment, and a curriculum designed to lead students outward toward the world, all within a diverse, faith-based community. While the school integrates many features associated with classical education (habits and formation, emphasis on moral purpose, a non-secular worldview, and a community-centered approach), several hallmark classical elements—prominent Great Books/Great Conversation mandates, explicit Trivium/Quadrivium content, and a fully articulated seven liberal arts framework—are not stated in their public materials. As a result, the overall classification is best described as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL, with clear needle-movers available to reach full CLASSICAL status.

Key insights include: - Strong religious and metaphysical foundations: a Christ-centered, Bible-inclusive environment, daily prayer/memory of Scripture, and explicit grounding in truth as a divine objective. - Purpose and formation emphasis: explicit aim to form the whole person (mind, body, spirit) and to lead students toward virtue and service. - Curriculum and pedagogy reflect Charlotte Mason influence: living books, narration, habit formation, and a worldview-led, integrative approach, but with limited explicit Great Books or Trivium/Quadrivium articulation in public content. - Faculty and community: visible leadership and staff structure with a focus on mentorship and community involvement; robust parent/community engagement through resources, volunteering, and governance. - The public material includes pathways for active parental involvement and community partnerships, which aligns well with classical expectations for parental partnership.

Score: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (aggregate). See category-by-category details below for category-specific keyword analysis, evidence, and rationale.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - City School presents a Christ-centered, biblical framework and explicitly grounds education in a created-by-God anthropology. Vision emphasizes a Christ-centered education accessible to a diverse community. The Philosophy of Education describes training the “whole child – mind, body, and spirit,” grounded in truth that all children are made in God's image. The Middle School page notes memory of Scripture and daily prayer, which underscores liturgical/communal practice.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: truth, God, Christ-centered, foundation of truth, living curriculum, Habits/Character, beauty/order (via “beautiful and orderly environment”). The school explicitly references truth as a divine reality, a Christian worldview, and a liturgical rhythm through scripture memory and prayer. - Negative indicators: none evident in public materials (no explicit secular or relativistic framing found).

Why this rating - The presence of a Christ-centered, biblically grounded worldview with daily Scripture memory and prayer, plus a stated aim to form minds and souls in line with divine truth, aligns with classical expectations for a strong religious/metaphysical foundation. It demonstrates transcendental/moral realism and liturgical/community life, supporting a CLASSICAL orientation in this category.

Citations: Vision/Christ-centered framing (turn0file12); Philosophy of Education (turn0file18); Bible/prayer focus (turn0file4).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public statements emphasize formation of the whole person (mind, body, spirit) and the development of character through habits, consistent with the classical emphasis on formation over mere information. City School describes its aim to form children academically, spiritually, and relationally, not simply to prepare for work.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: formation, habits, character, virtue formation (via “habits” and “character development”); love of learning; holistic education (mind, body, spirit). These map to the Positive Keywords set (Formation, Habits, Character, Virtue, Holistic Education, Great Conversation-style engagement through “living books” and the Big Ideas). - Negative indicators: none identified in public materials.

Why this rating - The school centers its mission on formation and virtue rather than job-centric outcomes, which corresponds to the Classical framework’s emphasis on truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, and formation of humane excellence.

Citations: Mission/vision and philosophy (turn0file12, turn0file18).

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is described as Charlotte Mason–inspired, with a focus on living books, a broad and integrated approach, and a “lead-out” pedagogy that connects ideas across disciplines. There is explicit use of Story of the World for history in elementary grades and “living books” in the upper grades; students memorize Bible verses, narrate, and study literature, history, and the arts. There is a notable emphasis on a holistic, interwoven curriculum rather than a strict Great Books canon, and no explicit statement of Trivium/Quadrivium or formal Great Books program in public materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: living books, great works by masters (artists/poets/composers) noted as part of the curriculum; Story of the World history program; multi-disciplinary approach and “lead out” philosophy; Bible memorization and prayer; narrative/narration across grades. These reflect components of the Six Essential Elements’ Curriculum Content and Structure, including living books, integration, and wonder. - Negative indicators: not explicitly listing the Seven Liberal Arts (Trivium/Quadrivium) or a formal Great Books canon as the core framework in public materials; no explicit universal Great Conversation framework stated. This limits a full CLASSICAL categorization in this area.

Why this rating - The curriculum demonstrates strong classical-adjacent features (habits, living books, integrated approach, reverence for literature and history, and a “lead out” pedagogy), but it stops short of explicitly articulating the full Seven Liberal Arts and Great Books framework within the public materials. This places it in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL for this category.

Citations: Story of the World and living books elements (turn2file11, turn2file9); Philosophy of Education emphasis on living curriculum (turn0file18); Masterworks in arts (turn3file2).

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogy emphasizes narration, memory, and a communal learning approach, with students engaging in narrations, discussions, and explanations rather than solely direct teacher instruction. Bible memorization and prayer are integrated into daily life, and there is a clear emphasis on forming habits as part of the learning process. The public materials speak to an approach that includes both contemplative/restful elements and active inquiry, with upper-grade discussion and rhetorical skills introduced as students progress.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: narration; memory/recitation; contemplative habit-building; learning through living books; communal discussions; the “lead out” approach. These align with the Positive Keywords for Pedagogy (Socratic dialogue, restfulness/scholé, memorization/recitation, formation through imitation and practice). - Negative indicators: explicit Socratic seminars or high-school-level dialectic in public materials are not stated; no clear evidence of formal high-school-level Socratic seminars. This is not necessarily disqualifying (the framework allows K–8 classical pedagogy to be classical even without 9–12 Socratic seminars), but it limits full CLASSICAL alignment in pedagogy for all grades.

Why this rating - The teaching methods strongly reflect traditional formation through memory, narration, and integrated living-text instruction, with a Miss Mason–style emphasis on the “habits” and “lead out” pedagogy. However, the explicit presence of Socratic/dialectic seminars or formal high-school rhetoric instruction is not clearly stated within the City School public content, which places it in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for pedagogy.

Citations: Narration and Bible memorization (turn0file4); Philosophy of Education and lead-out language (turn0file18).

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - City School identifies a leadership team (Head of School, Dean of Admissions & Community Service, Director of Development) and a Board of Directors; there is a visible emphasis on professional leadership and faculty/staff engagement. The publicly available content shows a structured, mission-driven staff with a focus on community, family involvement, and mentorship. However, explicit statements that the faculty are “the living curriculum” or “model teachers” are not clearly asserted in the public content.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: faculty leadership, mentorship orientation, and a clear emphasis on teachers as part of the school’s mission; professional development mentions in the Annual Impact content. These map to Positive Keywords like “model teachers,” “mentors,” and “living curriculum.” The public materials do emphasize the role of teachers and leadership in the school’s mission. - Negative indicators: no explicit language in the public materials stating “the living curriculum,” “teachers as mentors” in the exact terms of the Positive Keywords list. The alignment is present conceptually but not explicitly language-matched across the site.

Why this rating - The leadership structure and emphasis on faculty roles align with classical expectations in spirit but lack explicit, consistent language tying faculty to the “living curriculum” and “mentorship/collegiality” as defined in the six-element rubric. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Citations: Leadership page (turn0file6); Mission/vision and faculty implications (turn0file12).

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - City School clearly positions itself as a community-centered, parent-partnered school with robust parent resources (Gradelink access, enrollment forms, parent tours), volunteer opportunities, and family engagement through annual reports and donor programs. The school explicitly references parent partnerships, opportunities for parent involvement, and a culture of community support.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: “Partnership with Families” (public materials emphasize parent involvement and co-education), “Gradelink” for parent access, volunteer opportunities, annual impact reports, and donor engagement; these reflect the Positive Keywords for the Parents & Community category (parent partnership, home-school collaboration, family engagement, community of learners, parental leadership, parent formation, lived tradition in the family). - Negative indicators: none identified in the public materials.

Why this rating - The school actively engages families as co-educators and provides multiple avenues for parent involvement, resource access, and transparent communication, which strongly aligns with the classical model in this category.

Citations: Parent resources and community engagement (turn0file13); Vision/mission framing and family engagement (turn0file12); volunteer opportunities (turn0file12 / turn0file16).

Aggregate Assessment - Category ratings: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL - School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL - Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Pedagogy — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Aggregate classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- Explicit Great Books / Great Conversation articulation: The classical rubric values mention Great Books and a formal Great Conversation as central to the liberal-arts curriculum. City School uses living books and a Charlotte Mason approach but does not publicly declare a Great Books/Great Conversation framework. Adding explicit language and content around Great Books, canonical Western texts, and regular high-level dialogues would move Element 3 (Curriculum) toward CLASSICAL and reinforce the overall classical alignment.
- Clear Trivium/Quadrivium presence in curriculum: The Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) are foundational to classical education but are not explicitly enumerated in City School's public materials. Incorporating a visible Trivium/Quadrivium pathway (even if embedded in lower-to-middle levels) would strengthen Element 3 and Element 4 alignment, and improve the overall Classical status.
- Strengthen explicit "living curriculum" language for faculty: The rubric emphasizes the faculty as the living curriculum and as mentors. Public materials could more explicitly describe faculty as living exemplars of virtue and as a core component of the curriculum (the "living curriculum" concept). This would lift Element 5 toward CLASSICAL and bolster the aggregate.
- Expand liturgical/communal practices: While City School demonstrates liturgical elements (Bible memory, daily prayer) and a Christ-centered environment, more explicit articulation of liturgical rhythms (chapel, liturgical calendar, sacred music, communal worship) would strengthen Element 1 and the overall alignment.
- Deepened historical-canonical engagement: Increasing explicit references to primary historical texts, canonical authors, and "great conversation" traditions would push Element 3 toward CLASSICAL and better reflect the knowledge-base criteria.

Note: The needle-moving recommendations are designed to push the school toward full CLASSICAL classification without compromising its current missional, Charlotte Mason-inspired approach.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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